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LAST-MILE DELIVERY CHALLENGES IN INDIAN E-COMMERCE: A CONSUMER PERSPECTIVE

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ABSTRACT:

The meteoric rise of online retail in India has fundamentally altered how consumers shop and placed enormous pressure on delivery and logistics systems. Despite the expansion of major platforms such as Flipkart, Amazon, Meesho, and Myntra, last-mile delivery remains one of the most persistent and difficult problem and barriers in the growth of digital shopping ecosystem. This research paper studies consumer perceptions of e-commerce delivery services, with special emphasis on last-mile delivery challenges, preferred delivery options, payment methods, and the role of technology in improving delivery efficiency.

A descriptive methodology was followed in this research, with primary information collected directly from participants a structured Google Forms questionnaire distributed among 59 respondents, predominantly from the 18-25 age group. The findings show that 74% of respondents have experienced delivery delays, with delivery agent shortage identified as the primary cause. 65% have faced failed delivery attempts, and 88% believe technology such as GPS tracking and route optimization can improve delivery efficiency. The study further finds that 78% of respondents believe delivery costs directly affect product pricing, and 50% prioritize faster delivery as the single most desired improvement. (Shikwasha et al., 2025, pp. 237-247)

The paper concludes that e-commerce companies have to invest in last-mile delivery infrastructure, delivery workforce management, and digital technology adoption to boost customer satisfaction, reduce delivery failures, and build long-term consumer loyalty in an increasingly competitive market.

Keywords: Last-Mile Delivery, E-Commerce, Consumer Satisfaction, Delivery Challenges, Digital Logistics, India

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

India's e-commerce industry has grown at a remarkable pace over the past decade, propelled by wider internet connectivity, rising smartphone adoption, and a steadily growing middle-income group with growing purchasing power. Major platforms such as Flipkart, Amazon, Meesho, and Myntra have collectively transformed the way Indian consumers shop, shifting purchasing behaviour from conventional physical stores to e-commerce platforms. According to industry estimates, the Indian e-commerce market is projected to reach USD 350 billion by 2030, making it one of the major fastest-growing digital retail markets across the globe. (India's e-retail market set to reach Rs. 16,27,540 crore (US\$ 190 billion) gross merchandise value (GMV) by 2030: Bain report, 2025)

However, behind the impressive growth figures lies a persistent operational challenge: last-mile delivery. Last-mile delivery refers to the final leg of the supply chain, the movement of goods from a distribution hub to the customer's doorstep. It is simultaneously the most critical and the most complex stage of the e-commerce fulfilment process. In India, last-mile delivery faces a unique collection of challenges including inadequate road infrastructure, address system inconsistencies, delivery agent shortages, high rates of failed delivery attempts, and the dominance of cash-on-delivery as a payment preference, which adds significant operational complexity and cost. (G, 2026)

For e-commerce companies, last-mile delivery is not simply a logistical concern; it is a direct determinant of customer experience and satisfaction. A perfect, timely delivery reinforces brand trust and promotes repeat purchases. A failed or delayed delivery, on the other hand, damages customer relationships, increases return rates, and drives consumers to competitor platforms. Comprehending consumer perceptions of delivery services is therefore essential for e-commerce firms trying to optimize their delivery operations and moreover preserve competitive advantage.

1.2 Research Problem

Despite the swift development of online commerce in India, last-mile delivery is still a significant pain point for consumers. High rates of delivery delays, failed delivery attempts, and discontent with delivery communication suggest that current logistics systems are struggling to keep up with growing purchaser expectations. (R & Devipriya, 2026) This study attempts to examine consumer experiences and perceptions of e-commerce delivery services, identify the main challenges in last-mile delivery, and assess the potential role of technology in handling these problems.

1.3 Purpose of the study

The objectives of the current research are as follows:

- To analyze consumer satisfaction levels with e-commerce delivery services in India
- To identify the primary causes of delivery delays and failed deliveries in the India online retail environment
- To examine customer choices regarding delivery speed, payment methods, and delivery options
- To assess consumer awareness of the influence of delivery costs on product pricing

- To evaluate the perceived influence of technology in enhancing last-mile delivery capability

1.4 Scope and Significance of the research

This research is significant for several reasons. First, it offers empirical consumer-level data on last-mile delivery challenges in India, a topic that is frequently discussed in sector reports but less commonly examined by structured primary research. Second, it delivers usable insights aimed at e-commerce companies, logistics providers, and decision-makers seeking to improve delivery infrastructure and service quality. Third, it supports the growing academic literature on ecommerce logistics in newly developing markets, with close attention to India's unique geographical, infrastructural, and consumer behaviour context.

The scope of the research centers primarily on individual consumers who have used e-commerce platforms, with particular relevance to young adults between the ages of 18 and 40 who represent the most active online shopping demographic in India. (Online, 2024)

2. LITERATURE ANALYSIS AND RESEARCH GAP

Last-mile delivery has emerged being among the most extensively researched topics in supply chain management and e-commerce logistics literature. Researchers and practitioners alike have acknowledged that the last mile is not only the most expensive component of the delivery chain accounting for up to 53% of total shipping costs according to some estimates but also the most impactful in terms of customer experience. (Last-Mile Delivery Costs Breakdown & How to Reduce Them, 2021) Chopra and Meindl (2016) defined supply chain performance along dimensions of efficiency, responsiveness, reliability, and flexibility. In the e-commerce context, last-mile delivery is the critical interface where all four of these dimensions converge. Customers evaluate their overall e-commerce experience largely based on the delivery interaction, making last-mile performance a main driver of customer satisfaction and retention. (Chenglai, 2025)

Mangiaracina et al. (2019) found several key challenges in last-mile delivery in emerging markets, including fragmented address systems, poor road conditions, high rates of recipient unavailability, and the operational burden of cash-on-delivery. Their research emphasized the requirement for innovative delivery models such as locker systems, crowdsourced delivery, and smart scheduling to overcome these structural barriers. Research by Lim et al. (2018) on e-commerce logistics in Asia pointed out the significant role that mobile technology and instant tracking play in improving customer satisfaction. Their observations indicate that customers who receive proactive delivery updates report significantly higher satisfaction levels, even when actual delivery times are unchanged, underscoring the psychological value of communication in the delivery experience.

Studies on Indian e-commerce specifically have pointed out the distinct challenges posed by the country's diverse geography, inconsistent postal addressing, and the high proportion of COD transactions. (R & Devipriya, 2026, pp. 775-780) Sharma and Agrawal (2020) found that COD-related failed deliveries cost Indian e-commerce companies billions of rupees annually in redelivery and return processing costs, making COD reduction a strategic priority for major platforms. (Over 25% of COD Orders Fail: A Major Dent in India's E-commerce Business, 2024) The growing adoption of artificial intelligence plus machine learning in logistics has create new opportunities for route optimization, demand prediction, and delivery scheduling. Research by Wang et al. (2021) demonstrated that AI-driven route optimization can reduce last-mile delivery times by up to 30% while simultaneously lowering fuel costs and carbon emissions.

Research Gap

Despite the extensive literature on last-mile delivery challenges worldwide, comparatively few research studies have examined consumer perceptions of e-commerce delivery services in the Indian context by structured primary research. Most existing Indian studies concentrate on operational and financial dimensions of logistics rather than the consumer experience perspective. (Marketing logistics and consumer behaviour: an empirical study on Indian e-shoppers, 2024, pp. 1-23) moreover, limited research has examined the relationship between delivery costs, pricing perceptions, and buyer willingness to pay for premium delivery options among Indian e-commerce users. This study intends to bridge this gap through delivering direct consumer-level views on delivery experiences, preferences, and improvement expectations.

3. DATA COLLECTION AND RESEARCH METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

The present research follows a descriptive study design to analyze consumer the present study follows a descriptive research approach to analyze consumer perceptions regarding last mile delivery challenges in Indian e-commerce. Descriptive research is appropriate here because it allows the systematic data gathering and analysis on current consumer experiences and attitudes without manipulating variables. (What is descriptive research?, 2026) The goal is to describe the nature and extent of delivery challenges as experienced by real consumers and to observe patterns regarding consumer preferences and expectations.

3.2 Research Method

A quantitative research method was used, involving the collection of numerical data through a standardized questionnaire. This approach provides standardized, comparable measurement of consumer views and preferences. (Marketing logistics and consumer behaviour: an empirical study on Indian e-shoppers, 2024, pp. 1-15) Statistical techniques was then applied to discover patterns and obtain meaningful conclusions about delivery challenges and buyer expectations in the Indian e-commerce context.

3.3 Data Sources

Primary information was gathered through a structured Google Forms questionnaire distributed to 59 respondents, including students, private-sector employees, and business owners. The questionnaire covered delivery satisfaction, delay experiences, payment preferences, technology perceptions, and improvement expectations.

Secondary Data: Secondary data was collected from academic journals, logistics sector reports, ecommerce company publications, and previously published research on last-mile delivery, supply chain management, and consumer behaviour in digital commerce environments.

3.4 Sampling Technique

A convenience based sampling was used to select respondents. This analyze was chosen for its usefulness and efficiency in collecting data from willing, accessible participants. While this limits the applicability of findings, it is appropriate for an exploratory study of this nature. (Admin, 2022) Future research with wider geographically diverse samples would help validate and extend the findings of this study.

3.5 Sample Size

A total of 59 respondents participated in the study. The sample comprised predominantly young consumers aged 18-25, including students, working professionals, and business owners with direct experience with online shopping platforms and delivery services in India.

3.6 Data Collection Instrument

A detailed questionnaire consisting of 17 carefully designed questions was used as the primary data collection tool. The questionnaire was structured around major themes including demographic background, shopping behaviour, delivery satisfaction, delay experiences, payment preferences, and technology perceptions. Both multiple-choice and scale-based questions were used to capture a comprehensive picture of consumer delivery experiences.

3.7 Data Analysis Techniques

Responses were assessed using descriptive analytical techniques, including frequency distribution and percentage analysis. These methods helped identify the most common consumer attitudes and experiences and allowed for clear comparisons across several question categories. (Ghosh et al., 2009) Results are displayed through tables for clarity and straightforwardness of interpretation.

3.8 Conceptual Research Model

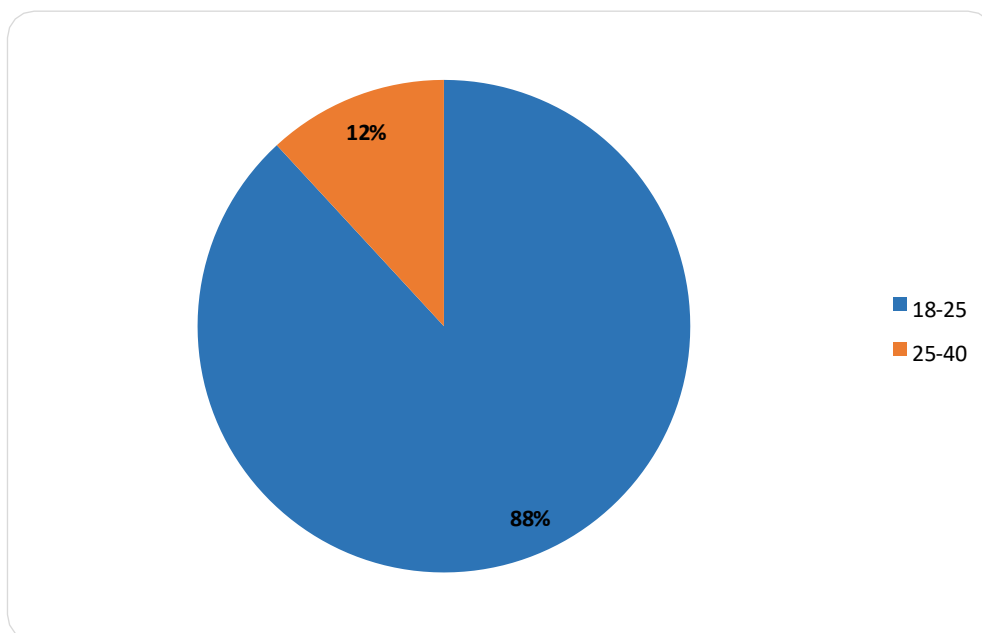
The conceptual framework of this research suggests that last-mile delivery challenges including delivery delays, failed attempts, high COD dependency, and poor communication negatively impact consumer satisfaction and experience. Consumer satisfaction, in turn, drives repeat purchase behaviour and platform loyalty. The model further suggests that technology adoption and infrastructure improvement can interrupt the negative cycle by reducing delivery failures and strengthening communication, thereby improving satisfaction outcomes. (R & Devipriya, 2026)

4. Analysis of Questionnaire Responses

4.1 DATA ANALYSIS AND FINDINGS

1. What is your age group?

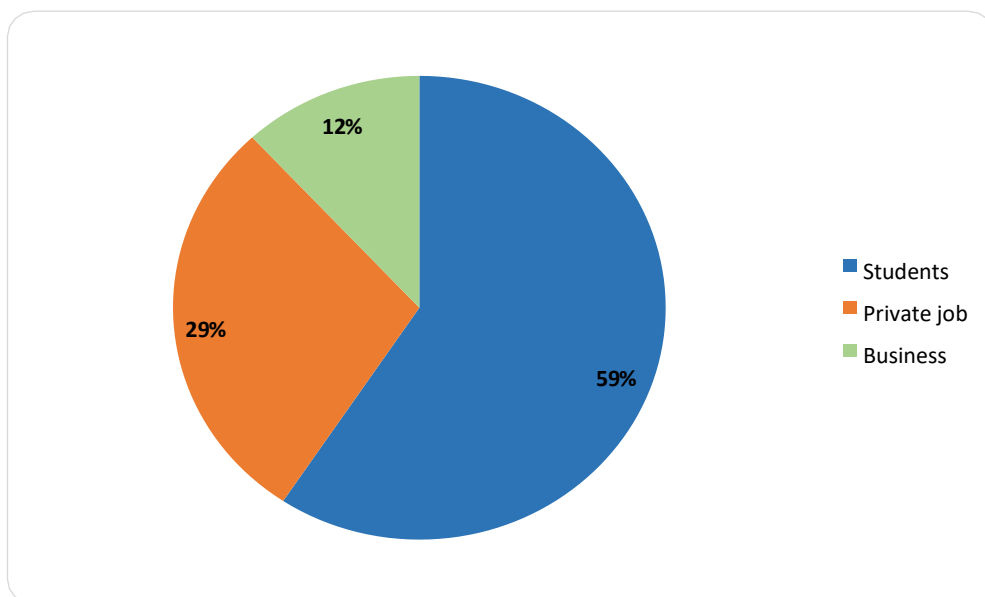
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
18-25	52	88%
25-40	7	12%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: Out of 59 respondents, 88% belong to the 18-25 age group, signifying strong participation of young consumers who are among the most active online shoppers in India. The remaining 12% fall in the 25-40 age group, indicating the study primarily captures the perspective of young adult e-commerce users.

2. What is your occupation?

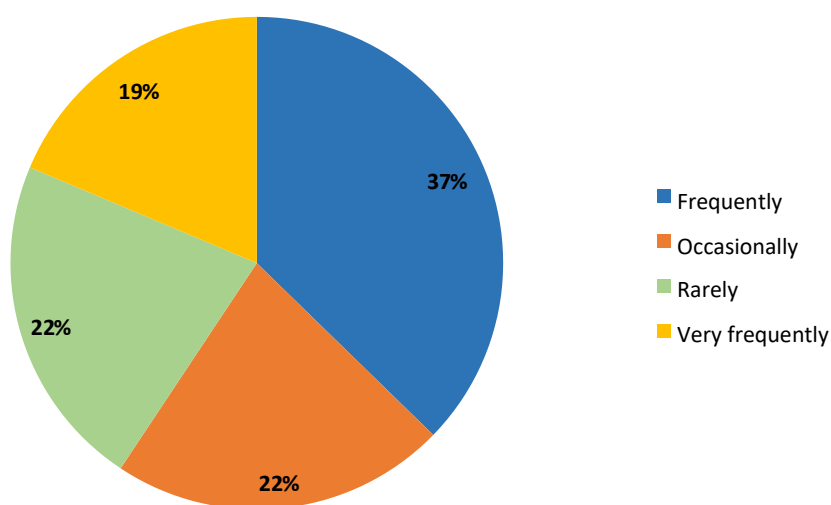
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Students	35	59%
Private job	17	29%
Business	7	12%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 59% of respondents are students, followed by private job holders at 29% and business owners at 12%. The dominance of students in the sample is consistent with the age distribution and reflects the growing trend of young consumers depending heavily on e-commerce platforms for their shopping needs.

3. How often do you shop online?

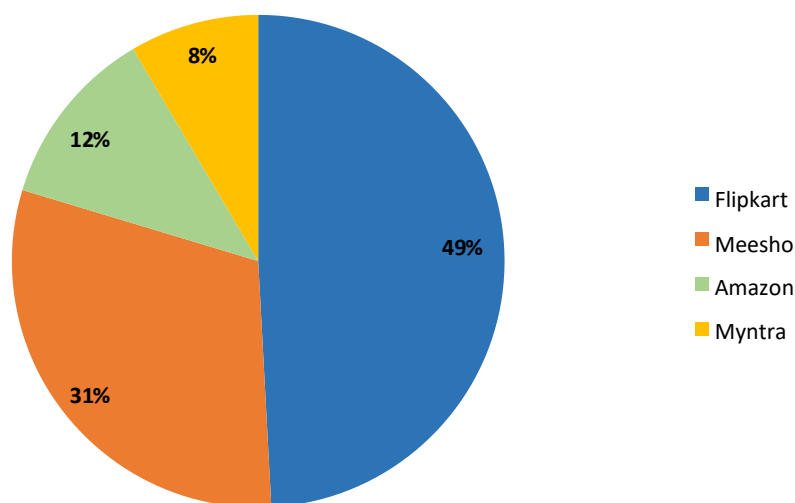
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Frequently	22	37%
Occasionally	13	22%
Rarely	13	22%
Very frequently	11	19%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 37% of respondents shop online frequently, while 19% do so very frequently, indicating that over half the sample are regular online shoppers. Only 22% shop rarely, suggesting that e-commerce has become an integral part of the shopping behaviour among the surveyed population.

4. Which e-commerce platform do you use most often? *Table 4: Most Used E-Commerce Platform*

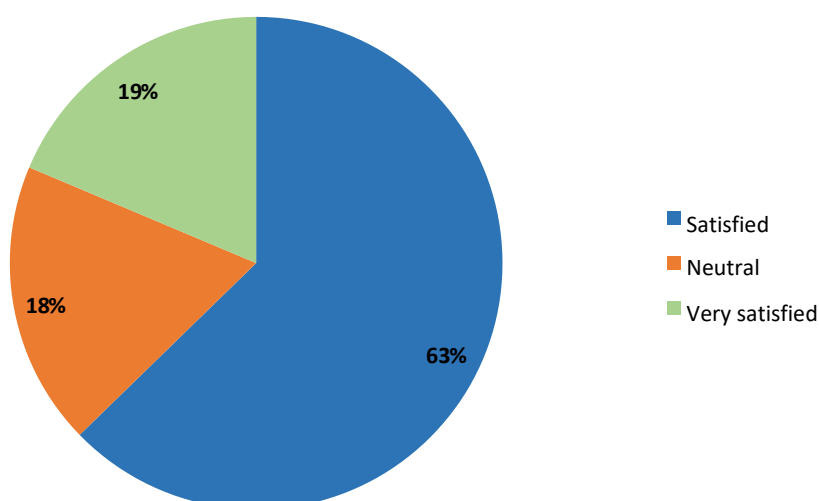
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Flipkart	29	49%
Meesho	18	31%
Amazon	7	12%
Myntra	5	8%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: Flipkart is the most preferred platform at 49%, followed by Meesho at 31%. Amazon and Myntra account for 12% and 8% respectively. Flipkart's dominance reflects its strong presence in the Indian market, while Meesho's significant share highlights the growing popularity of social commerce platforms among younger and price-sensitive consumers.

5. How satisfied are you with delivery services of e-commerce companies?

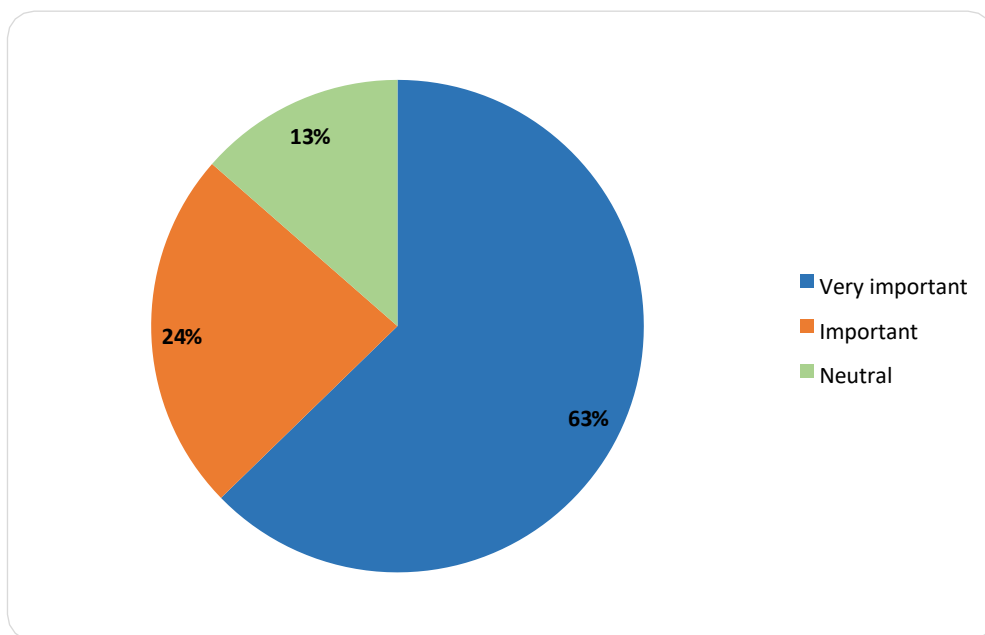
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Satisfied	37	63%
Neutral	11	19%
Very satisfied	11	19%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 63% of respondents are satisfied with e-commerce delivery services, and 19% are very satisfied, together indicating an 82% positive satisfaction rate. The remaining 19% are neutral, suggesting that while most customers are content with current delivery services, there is still notable room for improvement to achieve higher levels of customer delight.

6. How important is fast delivery when shopping online?

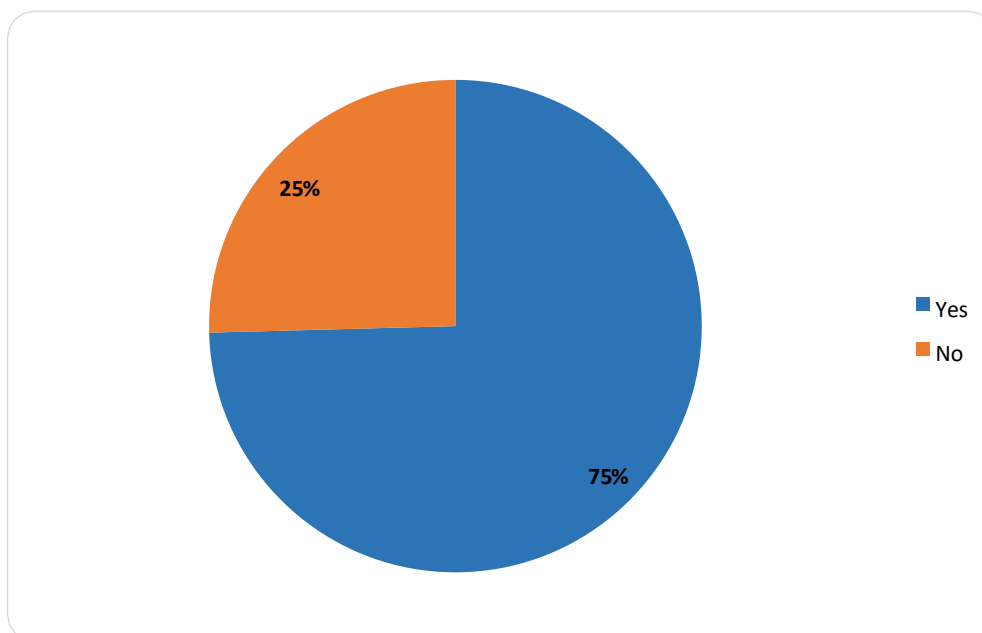
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Very important	37	63%
Important	14	24%
Neutral	8	14%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 63% of respondents consider fast delivery very important, and 24% consider it important, giving a combined 87% who prioritize delivery speed. This finding strongly underscores the critical role of delivery efficiency in shaping the overall e-commerce customer experience and influencing purchase decisions.

7. Have you ever experienced delayed delivery?

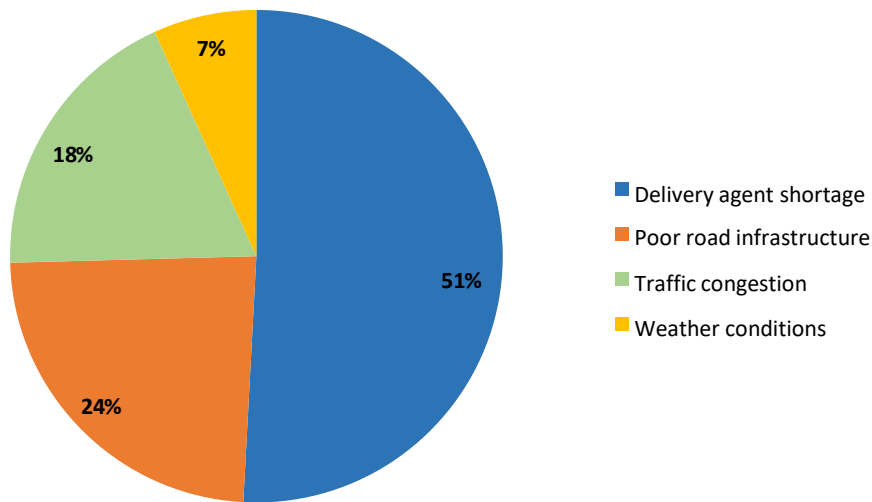
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Yes	44	75%
No	15	25%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: A significant 75% of respondents have experienced delayed delivery, while only 25% have not. This high incidence of delivery delays represents a major pain point for e-commerce consumers and highlights the urgent need for improvements in last-mile delivery infrastructure and logistics management across India.

8. What is the main reason for delivery delays in your area?

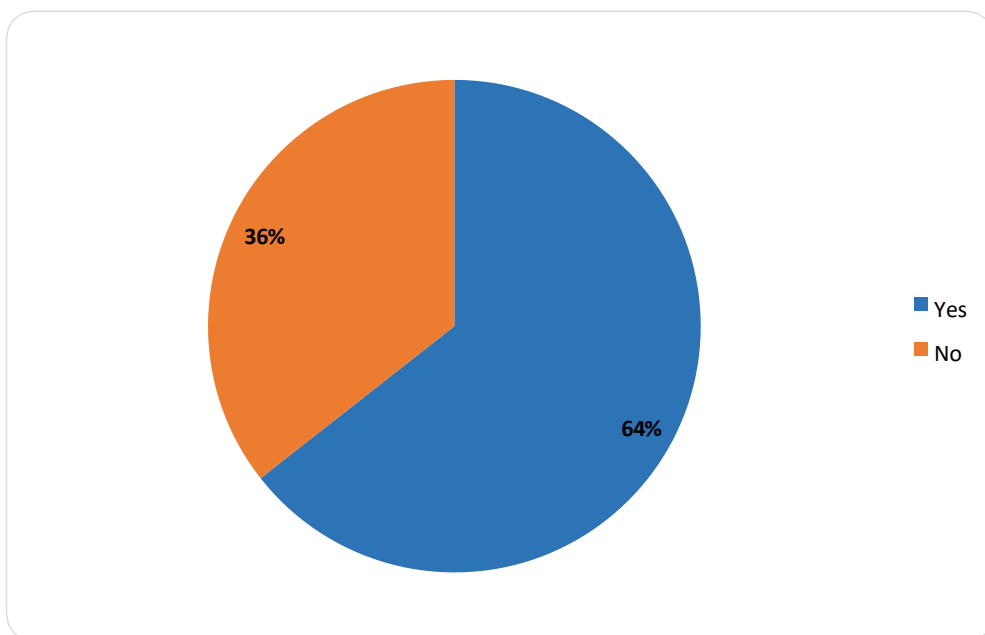
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Delivery agent shortage	30	51%
Poor road infrastructure	14	24%
Traffic congestion	11	19%
Weather conditions	4	7%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: Delivery agent shortage is identified as the primary cause of delays by 51% of respondents, followed by poor road infrastructure at 24% and traffic congestion at 19%. Weather conditions account for only 7%. These findings point to the need for better workforce management and infrastructure development to address the root causes of delivery delays.

9. Have you ever faced a failed delivery attempt?

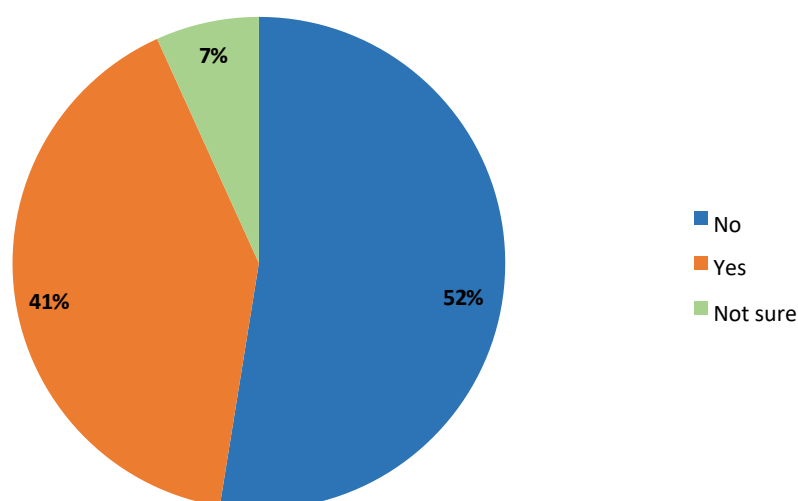
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Yes	38	64%
No	21	36%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 64% of respondents have experienced at least one failed delivery attempt, which is a concerning statistic for e-commerce companies. Failed deliveries significantly increase operational costs through re-delivery attempts, returns processing, and potential order cancellations.

10. Would you pay extra for same-day delivery?

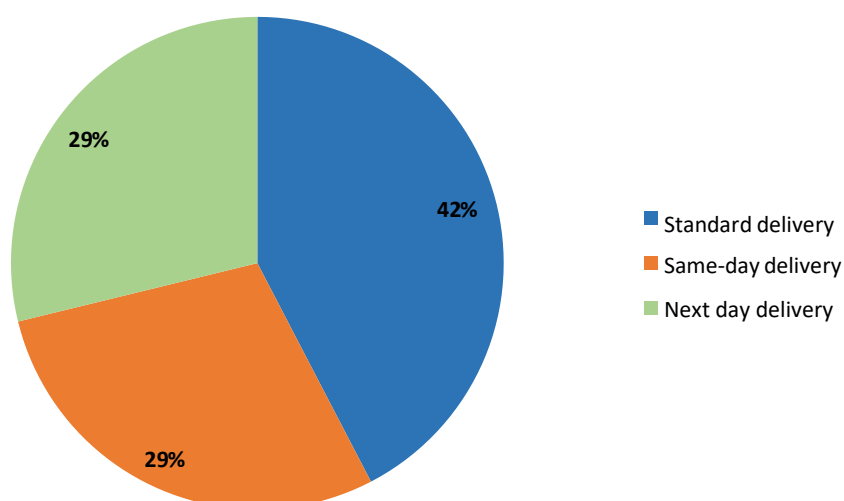
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
No	31	53%
Yes	24	41%
Not sure	4	7%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 53% of respondents are unwilling to pay extra for same-day delivery, while 41% are willing to do so. This near-even split suggests a price-sensitive consumer base that values speed but is cautious about additional charges.

11. Which delivery option do you prefer?

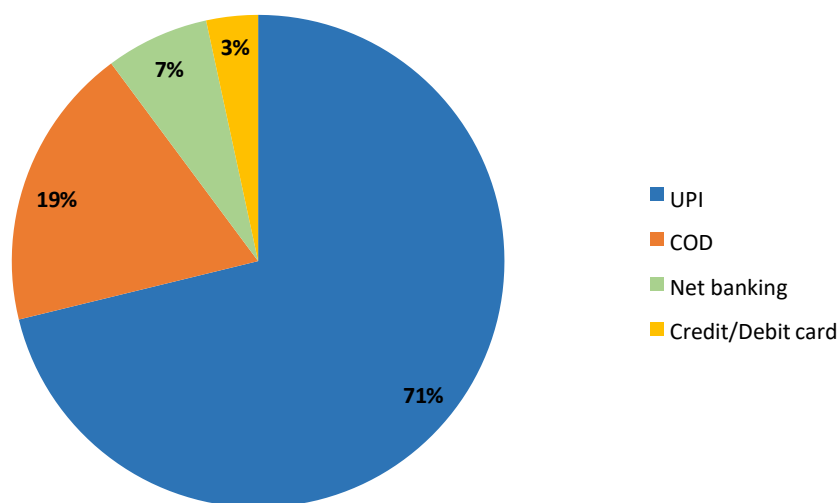
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Standard delivery	25	42%
Same-day delivery	17	29%
Next day delivery	17	29%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: Standard delivery remains the most preferred option at 42%, while same-day and next-day delivery are equally preferred at 29% each. A significant 58% prefer faster delivery options, indicating a growing demand for speed-oriented fulfilment strategies.

12. Which payment method do you usually use?

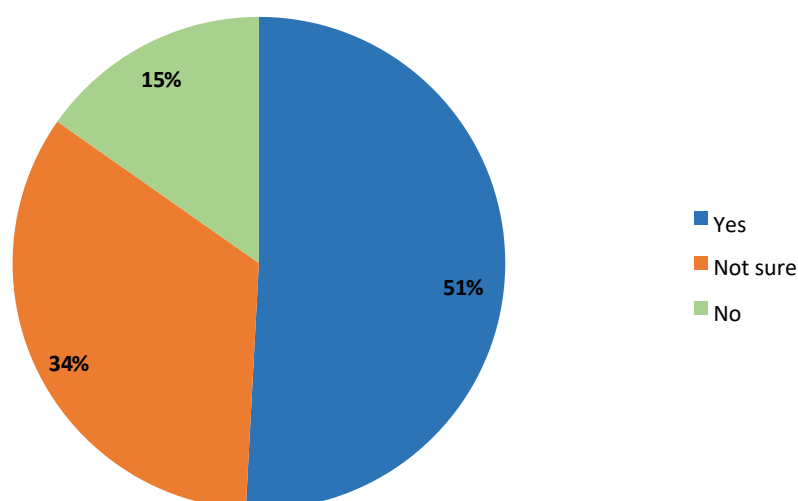
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
UPI	42	71%
COD	11	19%
Net banking	4	7%
Credit/Debit card	2	3%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: UPI dominates as the preferred payment method at 71%, reflecting India's rapid adoption of digital payments. COD accounts for 19%, still representing a significant segment of consumers who prefer cash transactions.

13. Do you think Cash on Delivery increases delivery cost for companies?

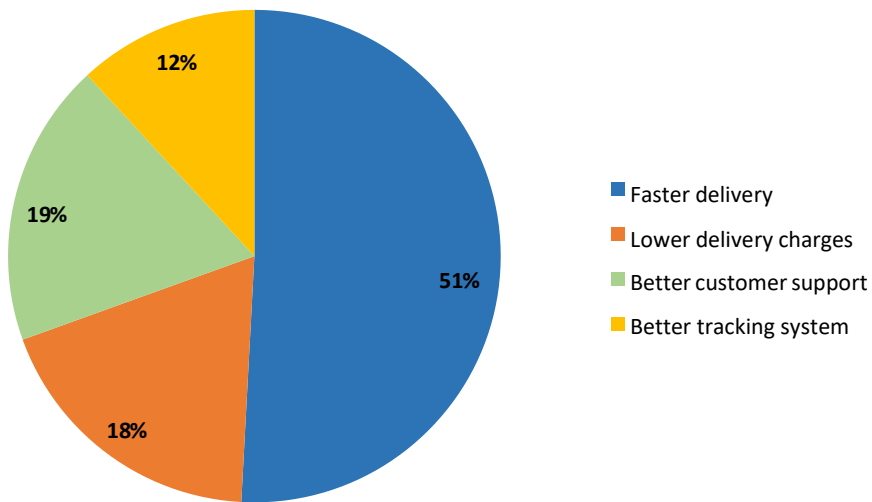
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Yes	30	51%
Not sure	20	34%
No	9	15%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 51% of respondents believe that COD increases delivery costs for companies, while 34% are uncertain and 15% disagree. The high level of uncertainty highlights an opportunity for companies to educate customers about the true cost of cash-based transactions.

14. What improvements would you like in e-commerce delivery services?

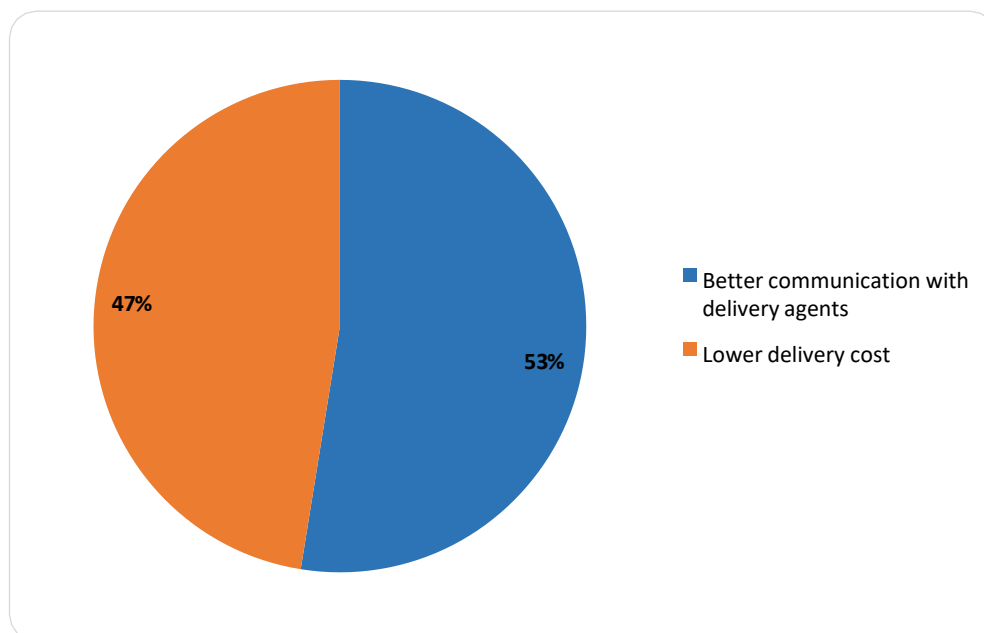
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Faster delivery	30	51%
Lower delivery charges	11	19%
Better customer support	11	19%
Better tracking system	7	12%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: Faster delivery is the top improvement requested by 51% of respondents, followed equally by lower delivery charges and better customer support at 19% each. Better tracking systems are desired by 12% of respondents.

15. What improvement would you like to see in last-mile delivery?

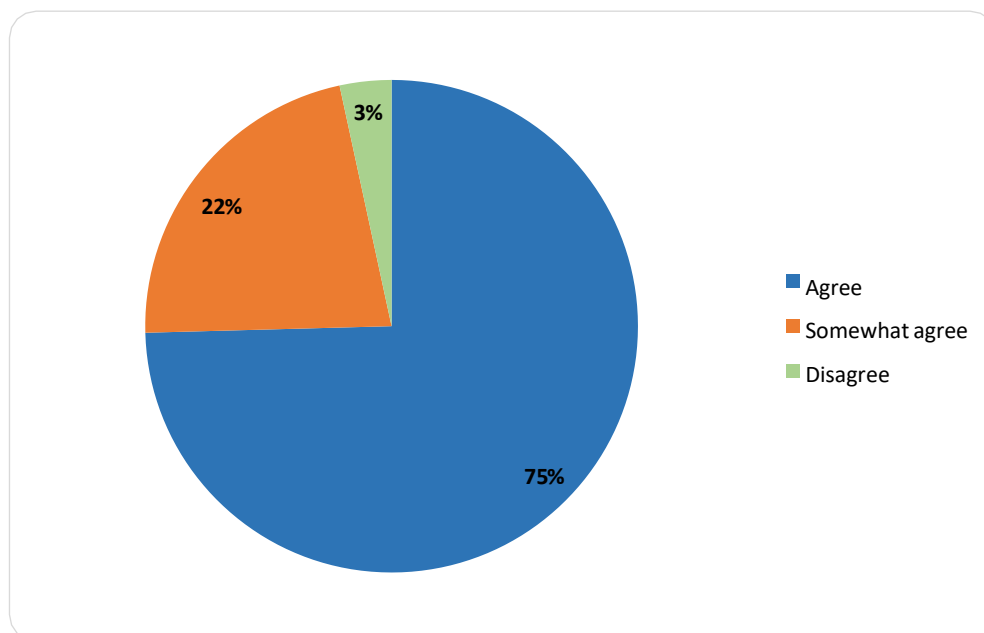
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Better communication with delivery agents	31	53%
Lower delivery cost	28	47%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 53% of respondents want better communication with delivery agents, while 47% prioritize lower delivery costs. Last-mile delivery improvement requires a dual focus on operational communication and making delivery economically accessible.

16. Do you think technology like GPS tracking and route optimization improves delivery efficiency?

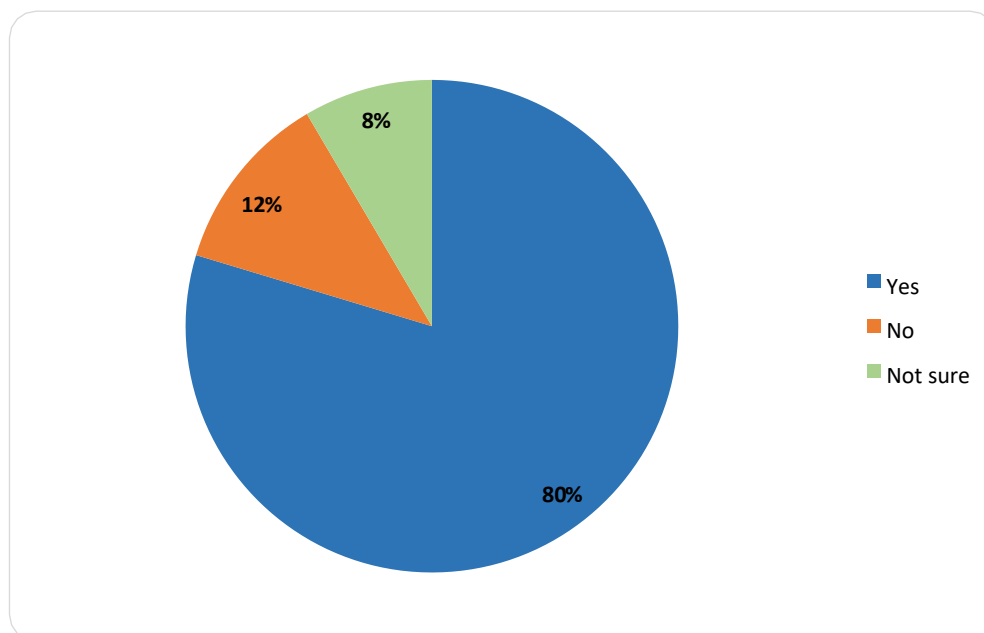
Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Agree	44	75%
Somewhat agree	13	22%
Disagree	2	3%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 75% of respondents agree that technology such as GPS tracking and route optimization improves delivery efficiency, and 22% somewhat agree, giving a combined 97% positive response.

17. Do you think delivery costs affect the product price in e-commerce?

Response	No. of Respondents	Percentage
Yes	47	80%
No	7	12%
Not sure	5	8%
Total	59	100%



Interpretation: 80% of respondents believe that delivery costs affect product pricing in ecommerce, confirming widespread consumer awareness of the relationship between logistics costs and retail prices.

4.2 Key Findings

Based on the analysis of 59 responses collected through a structured Google Forms questionnaire, the following key findings were identified:

The study reveals that delivery speed is the most critical factor in the e-commerce consumer experience, with 88% of respondents rating fast delivery as very important or important. Despite this, 74% have experienced delayed deliveries, primarily due to delivery agent shortages (52%), highlighting a significant gap between consumer expectations and operational reality.

Failed delivery attempts are a widespread issue, with 65% of respondents having experienced at least one such failure. Flipkart dominates platform preference at 47%, followed by Meesho at 31%, reflecting the diversity of the Indian e-commerce landscape. UPI has emerged as the dominant payment method at 72%, signalling a strong shift toward digital transactions even as COD continues to account for 19% of transactions.

Most significantly, 97% of respondents agreed that technology such as GPS tracking and route optimization improves delivery efficiency, and 78% believe delivery costs directly affect product pricing. These findings place technology adoption and cost optimization at the centre of any credible strategy to improve last-mile delivery in India.

4.3 Summary of Data Analysis

The data collected from 59 respondents through a structured Google Forms questionnaire provides a clear and consistent picture of consumer experiences and expectations regarding e-commerce delivery services in India.

The analysis consistently highlights that while overall satisfaction with e-commerce delivery is relatively positive with 80% of respondents reporting satisfied or very satisfied levels the high incidence of delivery delays (74%) and failed deliveries (65%) represents a significant operational gap that undermines the overall consumer experience. Delivery agent shortage emerges as the dominant cause of these failures, pointing to a structural workforce challenge that e-commerce and logistics companies must urgently address.

Consumer preferences reveal a growing appetite for faster delivery options, with 56% preferring same-day or next-day delivery. At the same time, price sensitivity remains a dominant characteristic of the Indian consumer base, with 53% unwilling to pay extra for same-day delivery. This tension between speed preference and cost sensitivity presents a critical strategic challenge for e-commerce delivery providers.

The near-unanimous endorsement of technology as a delivery improvement tool (97%) and the widespread belief that delivery costs affect product pricing (78%) underscore both the opportunity and the urgency for e-commerce companies to invest in intelligent logistics solutions that reduce costs while improving service quality.

5. FINDINGS AND DISCUSSION

The findings of this study provide significant insights into the state of last-mile delivery in Indian e-commerce and the gap between consumer expectations and current operational realities.

The most fundamental finding is that delivery speed and reliability are not simply desirable features they are foundational expectations that directly determine consumer satisfaction and platform loyalty. With 74% of respondents having experienced delayed deliveries and 65% having faced failed delivery attempts, it is clear that the current last-mile delivery system in India is not meeting the expectations of a significant majority of consumers. The primary driver of these failures delivery agent shortage, cited by 52% of respondents points to a human resource management challenge that is as important as any technological or infrastructural solution.

The study also reveals important insights about payment behaviour and its operational implications. While UPI dominates at 72% and represents a positive shift toward digital payments, the continued presence of

COD at 19% acknowledged by 50% of respondents to increase delivery costs highlights the ongoing operational burden that cash transactions place on e-commerce logistics systems. Reducing COD dependency through better digital payment incentives and consumer education represents both a cost reduction opportunity and a delivery efficiency improvement strategy.

The near-unanimous confidence in technology as a delivery improvement tool is one of the most encouraging findings of the study. With 97% of respondents agreeing that GPS tracking and route optimization improve delivery efficiency, there is a clear consumer mandate for technology investment. E-commerce companies that lead in technology adoption through real-time tracking, AI-driven route optimization, and proactive delivery communication are likely to achieve both operational efficiencies and higher consumer satisfaction scores.

Finally, the widespread consumer belief that delivery costs affect product pricing (78%) reinforces the strategic importance of last-mile cost optimization. When delivery costs are high, they inevitably flow through to consumers in the form of higher product prices or delivery charges, reducing the price competitiveness of e-commerce relative to traditional retail. Optimizing lastmile delivery costs is therefore not just an operational priority it is a direct driver of e-commerce market competitiveness.

6. CONCLUSION

The findings of this study, drawn from 59 respondents through a structured Google Forms survey, provide compelling evidence that last-mile delivery remains one of the most significant challenges and opportunities in Indian e-commerce. The data reveals that while consumer satisfaction with delivery services is broadly positive, the high rates of delivery delays (74%) and failed delivery attempts (65%) represent persistent operational failures that must be urgently addressed.

The study identifies delivery agent shortage as the primary driver of delivery delays (52%), placing workforce development and management at the centre of any credible last-mile improvement strategy. At the same time, the dominance of faster delivery preferences (56% preferring same-day or next-day options) against a backdrop of price sensitivity (53% unwilling to pay extra for sameday delivery) creates a complex strategic challenge: consumers want speed, but they are not uniformly willing to pay for it. This challenge can only be resolved through operational efficiency improvements that reduce the cost of faster delivery rather than simply passing costs on to consumers.

Technology emerges as the most powerful lever for addressing these challenges, with 97% of respondents agreeing that GPS tracking and route optimization improve delivery efficiency. Ecommerce companies

that invest in intelligent logistics technology including AI-driven routing, real-time tracking, predictive delivery scheduling, and automated communication systems are best positioned to close the gap between consumer expectations and operational reality.

In conclusion, improving last-mile delivery in India requires a holistic approach that addresses workforce challenges, leverages technology, reduces COD dependency, and builds transparent communication channels with consumers. Companies that treat last-mile delivery not merely as a cost centre but as a strategic differentiator will be the ones that earn lasting consumer loyalty and competitive advantage in the world's fastest-growing e-commerce market.

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